

Communication, FIFO Channels, and Time

Learning goal. Learn which messages represent network traffic, which messages are local timer events, what FIFO really guarantees, and how those facts determine timeout design.

Snapshot: feature/electionTransaction at d1222a2.

Key files: AbstractReplica.java, NetworkChannel.java, Replica.java, DistributedActor.java.

1. Two ways a message can move

The code has two importantly different delivery paths.

Protocol network path: a replica calls `broadcast` or `unicast`, which calls inherited `AbstractReplica.tell`. That method sends through a `NetworkChannel` actor, introducing configured latency while preserving FIFO order.

Local path: an actor sends to itself or uses `scheduleToItself`. The message enters the same actor's mailbox without passing through the simulated network.

These paths must not be confused. A heartbeat sent from the coordinator to followers is network traffic. A `HeartbeatTickMsg` telling the coordinator that it is time to send a heartbeat is a local scheduler event.

2. What `NetworkChannel` owns

Each replica lazily creates one `NetworkChannel` for each destination. Because the channel is a child of the sending replica, the effective identity is:

```
(source replica, destination replica)
```

The channel owns:

- the destination `ActorRef`;
- minimum and maximum delay;
- a FIFO queue of `(message, originalSender)` pairs; and
- a flag showing whether a delivery is already scheduled.

When a message arrives, `onEnqueue` places it at the tail. If no delivery is active, the channel schedules a private `Deliver` message to itself. `onDeliver` removes the head, sends it to the real destination using the saved sender, and schedules the next delivery if the queue is non-empty.

Only one queued message is scheduled at a time. That is what prevents a later random delay from overtaking an earlier message on the same channel.

3. The exact scope of FIFO

FIFO means:

If replica A sends message `m1` and then `m2` to replica B through the same channel, B receives `m1` before `m2`.

It does **not** mean:

- all messages in the entire system have one order;
- a message from A reaches B before a message from C reaches B;
- messages sent to different destinations arrive together; or
- a local timer message cannot be processed between two network messages.

Example:

```
A -> B: UPDATE U1
A -> B: WRITEOK U1      guaranteed in this order
C -> B: ELECTION E      may arrive before, between, or after them
B -> B: timeout T        may also be interleaved by the mailbox
```

This is why IDs, states, and stale-timeout checks are still necessary even with FIFO channels.

4. Preserving the logical sender

Without special handling, B would see the channel actor as `getSender()`. `NetworkChannel` therefore saves the original sender and calls:

```
destination.tell(message, originalSender)
```

Protocol message classes also contain an explicit `sender` field. The system therefore has two sender concepts:

- Akka envelope sender: supplied to `tell`;
- message metadata sender: stored inside `Msg`.

The implementation often uses explicit metadata because scheduled messages and forwarded transactions need stable, serializable correlation. A detailed code review should still check that the two identities cannot contradict each other in a security- or correctness-relevant way.

5. Broadcast and self-delivery

`Replica.broadcast(msg)` excludes the sender by default. This has an important consequence: a coordinator cannot rely on broadcasting `UPDATE` to count itself. The update FSM must represent the coordinator's local participation directly, normally by starting with ACK count one and applying locally when the quorum is reached.

`Replica.unicast` also returns without sending when the target is `getSelf()`. This prevents pointless network emulation but means any algorithm that logically sends to itself needs an explicit local path.

Both helpers stop sending once crash state is `CRASHED`.

6. Random delay range

`NetworkChannel.scheduleNextDelivery` computes:

```
minLatency + random.nextInt(maxLatency - minLatency)
```

The generated values range from `minLatency` through `maxLatency - 1`. It requires `maxLatency > minLatency`; equal bounds would make `nextInt(0)` invalid. This is an implementation constraint worth recording even though normal test constants satisfy it.

7. Timers are messages, not interrupts

`DistributedActor.scheduleToItself(delay, msg)` asks Akka's scheduler to enqueue `msg` later. The scheduler does not call transaction code directly and does not interrupt the actor.

This preserves actor encapsulation:

```
timer expires
-> timeout message enters owner's mailbox
-> owner dispatches it by TransactionId
-> transaction checks its current state/version
```

The delay is only the earliest intended enqueue time. Mailbox backlog and runtime scheduling can make processing later.

8. Why cancelling a timer is insufficient

Calling `Cancellable.cancel()` helps if the timeout has not been enqueued. It cannot pull a timeout message back out after it entered the mailbox.

Heartbeat demonstrates the safe pattern:

- 1 follower schedules watchdog version 4;
- 2 heartbeat arrives;
- 3 follower cancels version 4 and schedules version 5;
- 4 version 4 was already queued;
- 5 transaction receives it but rejects it because `4 != currentVersion`.

Cancellation saves work; version/state validation provides correctness.

The same reasoning should be applied to election forwarding attempts and any update timeout that can be replaced.

9. Designing timeout budgets

A safe timeout must exceed the longest valid path it is monitoring, including network hops and scheduling tolerance.

Examples:

- A read response needs a client-to-replica send and a replica-to-client reply, although current client traffic does not use `NetworkChannel` in the same way as replica traffic.
- An election ACK covers one delayed election send plus one delayed ACK return.
- A follower watchdog must allow several coordinator heartbeat intervals plus maximum propagation and scheduling tolerance.

`AbstractReplica.getMaxLatencyPlusTolerance` adds a replica-count-dependent allowance.

`HeartbeatTransaction` uses three missed heartbeat intervals plus that tolerance. These are implementation assumptions that should be justified against configured bounds rather than memorized as magic constants.

10. Failure and crash interaction

Reliable channels do not make a crashed destination reply. A queued message can still be delivered to its actor, but a correctly simulated crashed `Replica` ignores it. The sender then learns only through timeout.

Similarly, a replica may crash during a broadcast loop. `updateCrashStatusCallback` runs after sending activity, so a deterministic crash category can stop later protocol work. The exact point at which the crash counter changes is part of the fault model and belongs in the crash report.

11. Common misconceptions

- **“FIFO removes stale messages.”** No. It orders one channel; local timers and other senders can interleave.
- **“A scheduled message bypasses actor safety.”** No. It returns through the mailbox.
- **“A cancelled timeout cannot arrive.”** It may already be queued.
- **“Broadcast automatically includes the sender.”** This implementation excludes self unless requested.
- **“Reliable means immediate.”** It means eventual delivery under the model, still with delay.

12. What the tests currently establish

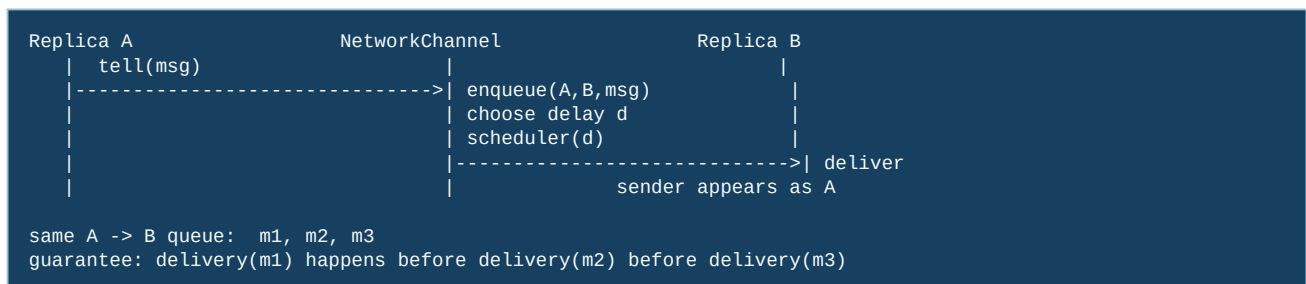
`TestDispatcher` checks transaction-ID routing behavior. `TestHeartbeatTransaction` checks periodic heartbeat broadcast and routing of heartbeat ticks. Election tests inspect timeout metadata and ring navigation. These are useful component checks, but they do not prove every cross-channel ordering or every timeout budget.

13. Exam rehearsal

If asked why `NetworkChannel` exists when Akka already sends messages, answer: it makes the course's network model visible—controlled random latency and FIFO order per source/destination pair—so tests can exercise distributed timing rather than zero-delay local actor delivery.

The invariant to remember is: **all replica-to-replica protocol traffic must use the simulated channel, while scheduler events remain local and must be validated when processed.**

14. A message's journey through the simulated network



FIFO is scoped to one ordered pair. If A sends `m1` and C sends `m2` to B, the channel may deliver either one first. This is why a protocol must put ordering information in its messages instead of assuming that “the first message I observe is the oldest update globally.”

15. Code microscope: delayed delivery versus local scheduling

The channel normally does three conceptually separate operations: append to the source/destination queue, calculate a delay, and schedule a delivery callback. A scheduler timeout in a transaction does not pass through this queue. It is a local event, so its timestamp says nothing about when a remote message was sent.

```
Conceptual channel logic:
q = queues.get(key(sender, target))
q.add(Envelope(sender, target, message)) // FIFO insertion
d = randomDelay()
scheduleOnce(d, deliverNext(key))

At delivery, preserve the original sender:
target.tell(envelope.message(), envelope.sender())
```

The final line matters: a follower should not accept a heartbeat or ACK merely because it arrived through a trusted channel; it should also verify the sender encoded by the envelope. When inspecting the real implementation, identify where `ActorRef.noSender()` is used and where the original sender is preserved. A lost sender can make every participant look like the coordinator.

16. Timing arithmetic students can reuse

Let L be the maximum one-hop network delay and H the heartbeat period. A follower that resets its watchdog after each heartbeat should use a timeout strictly larger than $H + L$ (usually with a safety margin). A two-hop quorum round needs roughly $2L$ network budget, plus scheduler and processing slack. These are not proofs of liveness, but they expose obviously impossible constants. If a timeout is smaller than one configured hop, healthy nodes will spuriously start elections.

17. Experiment and review questions

- 1 Send two messages from A to B and one from C to B. Which orderings are legal, and which would violate the channel contract?
- 2 Cancel a watchdog after its event has entered the mailbox. What additional field (for example, a generation/version) lets the handler reject it?
- 3 In a test, how would you distinguish “the message was delayed” from “the receiver crashed” without sleeping for an arbitrary number of seconds?